It's also possible that I'm misremembering my own struggles with memory from back then, because I do recall being very good at memorizing *some* things, like long passages from *Ace Ventura* and *The Lion King*. I'd recite them often, to mates, to myself. Also, there's a photo of me, sitting in my room, at my pull-out desk, and there amid the cubbyholes and chaotic papers sits a silver-framed photo of Mummy. So. Despite my clear memory of not wanting to remember her, I was also trying gamely not to forget her.

Difficult as it was for me to be the naughty one, and the stupid one, it was anguish for Pa, because it meant I was his opposite.

What troubled him most was how I went out of my way to avoid books. Pa didn't merely enjoy books, he exalted them. Especially Shakespeare. He adored *Henry V*. He compared himself to Prince Hal. There were multiple Falstaffs in his life, like Lord Mountbatten, his beloved great-uncle, and Laurens van der Post, the irascible intellectual acolyte of Carl Jung.

When I was about six or seven, Pa went to Stratford and delivered a fiery public defense of Shakespeare. Standing in the place where Britain's greatest writer was born and died, Pa decried the neglect of Shakespeare's plays in schools, the fading of Shakespeare from British classrooms, and from the nation's collective consciousness. Pa peppered this fiery oration with quotations from *Hamlet, Macbeth, Othello, The Tempest, The Merchant of Venice*—he plucked the lines from thin air, like petals from one of his homegrown roses, and tossed them into the audience. It was showmanship, but not in an empty way. He was making the point: You should all be able to do this. You should all know these lines. They're our shared heritage, we should be cherishing them, safeguarding them, and instead we're letting them die.

I never doubted how much it upset Pa that I was part of the Shakespeare-less hordes. And I tried to change. I opened *Hamlet*. Hmm: Lonely prince, obsessed with dead parent, watches remaining parent fall in love with dead parent's usurper…?

I slammed it shut. No, thank you.

Pa never stopped fighting the good fight. He was spending more time at Highgrove, his 350-acre estate in Gloucestershire, and it was just down the road from Stratford, so he made a point of taking me now and then. We'd turn up unannounced, watch whatever play they were putting on, it didn't matter to Pa. Didn't matter to me either, though for different reasons.

It was all torture.